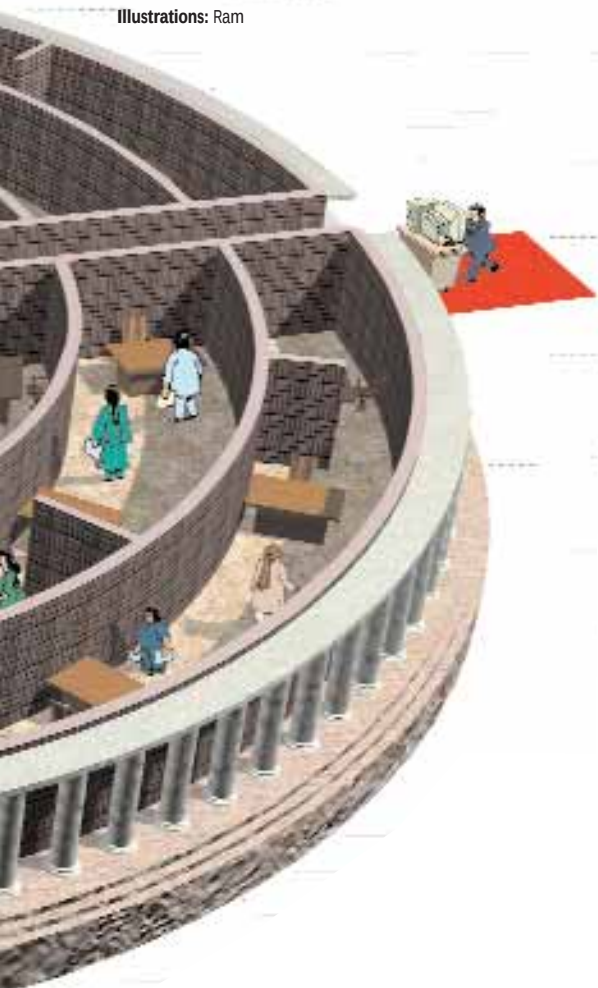


Illustrations: Ram



that will be automatically generated from a database, there is greater likelihood of transparency in the administrative system.

The e-nitiative

Keeping in mind the benefits of e-governance, the Ministry of Information Technology has declared 2001 the year of e-governance and is encouraging the state governments to work towards this. Training programmes on IT applications and e-governance are being held in many states for employees in government institutions.

The passage of the IT Act, 2000, is another step in promoting e-governance. The Act gives legal recognition to electronic documents and digital signatures and allows government records to be kept in electronic form. It even permits applications and forms to be filled up.

These processes are another step towards decentralisation—important for any meaningful decision-making process. Planning in four important sectors—services, environment, industry and agriculture—will be decentralised through active participation from people.

Challenges ahead

The greatest impact of e-governance will undoubtedly be felt in rural areas, where the bulk of our citizens reside. Herein lies a challenge as well as an opportunity for the government.

Due to the extremely low level of penetration of IT in the Indian society, the government will face cultural and attitudinal barriers not just from the masses but from employees as well. Communication barriers will also have to be overcome. It is unlikely that the layman in rural India will understand any other language besides his own mother tongue. So, multilingual

—it works!

applications, get information online about the status of applications, obtain other general information about any government department, deposit state levies and taxes and even file your returns electronically. Under ideal conditions, citizens will be able to undertake basic tasks or gather information such as application status for a passport, filling in provident fund forms, etc, without ever having to visit any government office.

Provision of such information through e-governance will reduce one step in the chain of activities, thereby doing away with a bit of the red tapism normally associated with government services. And because most transactions that occur can be monitored easily through reports

software packages with user-friendly interfaces are being developed that can work across platforms and be used in different states. A start has been made and it is heartening. Here are two examples of how e-governance is bringing a new wave of change across the countryside.

Case I: Dhar—the messenger of knowledge

The Dhar district in Madhya Pradesh has used e-governance in an exemplary manner. Their project, called Gyandoot, has been envisaged to cater to the social, economic and developmental needs of the villagers through an innovative G2C (government to citizen) model. Gyandoot is basically an intranet connecting rural cybercafes and

Andhra Pradesh: Digital State

Andhra Pradesh claims to be on the fast-track towards the digital age with chief minister Chandrababu Naidu championing the cause of providing IT for the masses.

Apswan: Network for voice, data and video communication throughout Andhra Pradesh. Operational with 2 Mbps fibre optic links and scalable up to more than 600 Mbps, connecting the State Secretariat with 25 centres.

Card Project: Manual system of registering and preserving documents of immovable property transactions replaced by a simple and transparent system.

Fully Automated Services of Transport: Provides services such as issuing learner's licenses, driving licenses and registration of vehicles through a comprehensive, networked solution.

Secretariat Knowledge Information Management System: Generic product that efficiently manages information and knowledge at the Secretariat.

Andhra Pradesh Development Monitoring System: A system that helps in research, analysis, project design and monitoring of state projects.

AP is putting efforts not only into transforming government activities into e-mode, but is also giving a secured environment to the IT market—from production and trading companies to educational institutions and consultancies. Keeping future investment in view, AP has established a new technology park named Hi-Tech City. It has its own power supply and broadband telephone lines for faster Internet communication.